I was instigating the Russian.

Finally he sought a couple of clarifications, which the Caltech man explained, again through a maze of equations.

Professor Srignano egged the Russian on.

Now the Russian friend stood up.

'Your theories are against some fundamental equations of thermodynamics,' he told the presenter who now invited him to the podium to prove his point.

The Russian took a piece of chalk and moved to a corner of the podium where the blackboard still had a little space. He started scrawling furiously, reeling out equations all the while. This went on for some twenty minutes. At the end of it, he had demolished the Caltech man's research paper. He walked shyly back to the chair next to me even as Professor Srignano and the rest of the crowd pondered over his scrawls on the blackboard. There was absolute silence. The Russian whispered to me.

'Mate, you exposed me.'

The rest of the audience now grilled the Caltech scholar. The poor man lost it. The incident influenced my perception about two things. One: Russians are sharp. Two: an American university hall full of scientists can easily miss a bloomer in thermodynamics.

Well, if that sounds as a conditioned prejudice, there were others who had more misplaced notions about Indians. It could be out of some one-off experience that a Turkish professor at Princeton had. He believed Indians were poor in mathematics.

The professor was working on a mathematical problem for the class and I kept asking questions. At one point he got irritated and asked me: 'Where are you from?'

'India,' I replied.

'No wonder you can't understand what I am saying.'

This was more an insult for me than shock. It was personal, it was racial; I had never scored anything less than full marks in maths right from school. And to brand Indians weak in maths was a collective affront on a nation that had given birth to such greats as Ramanunjan, C V Raman and